

ENG 111: Public Speaking

- Lecture 4: Nonverbal Messages
- Fall 2026 | Class 4 | Chapter 5
- Focus: Communicating through facial expressions, eye contact, gestures, posture, voice, appearance, space, and time

Today's 90-Minute Class

- Warm-up and recap — 10 min
- Introduction to nonverbal communication — 15 min
- Major forms of nonverbal messages — 20 min
- Examples and interpretation — 10 min
- Pair work — 15 min
- Group activities — 15 min
- Reflection and wrap-up — 5 min

Warm-Up: Communicate Without Words

- Do not speak for 30 seconds.
- Show your partner: happiness, confusion, disagreement, nervousness, or excitement.
- Your partner guesses the meaning.
- DISCUSS: Which clues helped you understand the message?
- Sample explanation: Facial expression, posture, gestures, and eye contact can communicate meaning without spoken words.

What Is Nonverbal Communication?

- Nonverbal communication involves messages expressed without relying only on words.
- It includes facial expressions, gestures, posture, eye contact, vocal qualities, appearance, use of space, and other behaviours.
- Important idea: In real communication, verbal and nonverbal messages often work together.

Why Does Nonverbal Communication Matter?

- Nonverbal behaviour can support, strengthen, change, or contradict spoken words.
- Example: A student says, “I am very confident,” while avoiding eye contact and speaking in a trembling voice.
- DISCUSS: Which message might the audience believe more? Why?
- Sample explanation: When verbal and nonverbal messages conflict, audiences often pay close attention to visible behaviour and vocal cues.

Facial Expressions

- Our faces can communicate emotions and reactions.
- Examples: smiling may communicate friendliness; raised eyebrows may suggest surprise; a frown may suggest concern or disagreement.
- However, interpretation depends on context.
- PAIR QUESTION: Can a smile always mean happiness?
- Sample explanation: No. A person may smile because of politeness, nervousness, embarrassment, or irony.

Eye Contact

- Eye contact can help speakers connect with an audience.
- Appropriate eye contact may communicate attention, confidence, and involvement.
- Too little eye contact may make a speaker seem disengaged; staring continuously may make listeners uncomfortable.
- Example: During a presentation, look naturally at different sections of the audience rather than reading only from the screen.

Gestures

- Gestures are movements of the hands, arms, or body that communicate meaning.
- Example: Open hands may help communicate openness; pointing may direct attention.
- For speakers, gestures should support the message rather than distract from it.
- Example: Saying “three important points” while clearly showing three fingers can reinforce the organization of a speech.

Posture and Body Movement

- Posture can influence how a speaker appears to an audience.
- Example: Standing upright and facing the audience may communicate readiness and engagement.
- Constantly shifting, hiding behind a desk, or turning away may distract from the message.
- Sample explanation: Effective delivery requires awareness of how movement affects audience attention.

Voice as a Nonverbal Message

- How we say something can influence meaning.
- Consider volume, pitch, rate, pauses, and vocal variety.
- Example: “I can’t believe you did that!”
- Say it with excitement, anger, surprise, and disappointment.
- PAIR ACTIVITY: Take turns saying the sentence in two different ways. Guess the intended emotion.

Personal Appearance

- Appearance can contribute to first impressions.
- For public speaking, consider whether your appearance is appropriate for the occasion, audience, and purpose.
- Example: Clothing appropriate for a formal job presentation may differ from clothing appropriate for an informal student club event.
- DISCUSS: Why should speakers consider context rather than follow one single rule for every situation?

Use of Space

- People communicate partly through how they use physical space.
- Example: A speaker who moves closer to the audience during an important point may create greater involvement.
- A speaker should also respect personal boundaries and the physical setting.
- Question: How might a small classroom require different movement from a large auditorium?

Time and Communication

- Timing can influence how a message is received.
- Example: Arriving late for an important presentation may communicate poor preparation or disregard for others' time.
- Pauses can also be meaningful.
- Example: A brief pause before an important point can give the audience time to focus.

Nonverbal Messages Can Contradict Words

- Example 1: “I am listening,” while checking a phone.
- Example 2: “I am happy to answer your questions,” spoken with an impatient tone.
- Example 3: “This is very important,” while looking away and speaking quietly.
- PAIR DISCUSSION: Which verbal and nonverbal messages conflict? How could the speaker improve?

Nonverbal Messages in Public Speaking

- A public speaker should try to make verbal and nonverbal messages work together.
- Example: When introducing an exciting opportunity, a speaker may use an energetic voice, natural gestures, and engaged eye contact.
- Sample explanation: Congruence means different elements of communication support the same overall message.

PAIR WORK 1: Read the Situation

- With a partner, choose one situation:
- A. A student receives an unexpectedly high grade.
- B. A student is asked a difficult question in class.
- C. A person is waiting for an important interview.
- D. A group member disagrees with a decision.
- Without speaking, act out the situation. Your partner identifies the likely emotion and the nonverbal clues used.

Pair Work 1: Sample Explanation

- Example: Difficult question in class.
- Possible nonverbal cues: looking away, pausing, tightening facial muscles, shifting posture, or nervous gestures.
- Possible interpretation: The student may be uncertain or nervous.
- Important reminder: One cue alone does not always prove a person's exact feelings; context matters.

PAIR WORK 2: Improve the Speaker

- Partner A delivers this line: “I am very pleased to present this topic to you today.”
- First, deliver it with poor nonverbal communication: no eye contact, monotone voice, closed posture.
- Then deliver it effectively: natural eye contact, vocal variety, open posture, and purposeful gestures.
- Partner B gives feedback using specific observations.

Sample Pair Feedback

- Instead of saying: “Your presentation was good.”
- Try: “Your second delivery was more engaging because you looked at the audience and changed your voice to emphasize important words.”
- Constructive suggestion: “Try to pause after your main point so the audience has time to understand it.”
- Key idea: Good feedback describes observable behaviour and suggests improvement.

GROUP ACTIVITY 1: Silent Scene

- Groups of 4–5 create a 30–45 second scene without spoken words.
- Choose one situation: a group disagreement, receiving good news, missing an important deadline, confusion during a meeting, or preparing for an exam.
- The class identifies the situation and the nonverbal cues.
- Planning questions: What should the audience notice? Which gestures, expressions, posture, and movement will help?

Sample Explanation: Silent Scene

- Situation: Group disagreement.
- One student crosses their arms and looks away; another leans forward and gestures strongly; a third tries to calm the group with open hands.
- Possible interpretation: The first may appear resistant, the second strongly involved, and the third may be attempting to reduce tension.
- Explain that interpretation depends on the whole context, not on one gesture alone.

GROUP ACTIVITY 2: Nonverbal Makeover

- Each group receives a presentation scenario.
- Scenario: A student presents an important proposal but speaks too quickly, looks only at the slides, stands still with closed posture, and uses a monotone voice.
- Task: Identify four nonverbal problems and demonstrate an improved version.
- Prepare a one-minute before-and-after demonstration.

Sample Group Response

- Problem: Looking only at slides → Improvement: Use slides as support and look naturally at the audience.
- Problem: Speaking too quickly → Improvement: Slow down and pause between major ideas.
- Problem: Closed posture → Improvement: Stand comfortably and use natural gestures.
- Problem: Monotone voice → Improvement: Vary emphasis, pace, and tone to highlight meaning.

Mini Presentation Practice

- Volunteers deliver a 30-second introduction to any familiar topic.
- Class observes: facial expression, eye contact, posture, gestures, voice, and movement.
- Feedback formula:
 1. One effective nonverbal behaviour
 2. One specific suggestion
- Example: “Your eye contact helped me feel included. You could pause more after important ideas.”

Key Takeaways

- Nonverbal communication includes more than facial expressions and gestures.
- Context influences interpretation.
- Verbal and nonverbal messages should support each other.
- Public speakers should use eye contact, posture, gestures, movement, and voice purposefully.
- Observe carefully before making assumptions about another person's feelings or intentions.

Exit Ticket

- Write three short answers:
- 1. Which type of nonverbal communication do you think is most important for public speaking? Why?
- 2. Give one example of verbal and nonverbal messages contradicting each other.
- 3. Name one nonverbal skill you want to improve before your first speech.

Next Class

- Next topic: Language
- Think about how language influences meaning and audiences.
- Bring one example of a word or phrase that may sound positive in one context but negative or inappropriate in another.
- Thank you!